

sign up. You'll need to use an existing credit/debit card to create an account and you'll need to transfer a token amount to activate a virtual credit card. Entropy does charge an overhead of 5% for every transfer to the card, but you don't really need to pay more than once if you're only using the card for activating an international account.

Recommended setup

Considering the kind of service we would expect from the ideal TV, nothing short of a decent HTPC will be sufficient for our needs. You can pick the config we've mentioned in our Killer Rigs section on page 112 or you can build your own depending on your budget.

We would recommend the following:

- An Intel i3 or AMD A4 class CPU
- At least 4GB RAM
- A 1TB HDD for your storage needs (you can add an SSD to boost the responsiveness if you so desire)
- An AMD or Nvidia GPU if you're into serious gaming
- A Windows compatible media centre remote (available online for about ₹3,000) for navigating the interface. A keyboard/mouse combo or gamepad would be cumbersome, but does work.
- A DLNA-ready router that allows you to access and share content from USB drives (USB 3.0 for better speed, but it's not essential). A router such as the ASUS N600 or NetGear N600 will set you back by about ₹6,000-8,000, but if you're streaming over Wi-Fi, an N600 certified router is what you'll need.
- An HDMI switch will be required if you're going to be connecting a lot of devices to your TV. The switch will let you switch to the HDMI stream of your choice, be it from your Xbox, Set Top Box, or Apple TV, etc.
- Windows 8.1's UI finally serves a purpose here; it's Modern UI is perfectly at home on a large screen.
- PC remote server: This is a program that will run on the HTPC and let you control the system via a mobile phone
- XBMC / Windows Media Centre / etc.: A media centre program would be best if you intend to sit on the couch and stream content to your TV.
- iTunes will be required if you're using Apple devices and it will be required



HTPCs can be cool too

if you want to stream the contents of your iTunes library to your iDevices.

- If you're a gamer, then you can't have a PC without Steam. The service is, after all, the only game DRM that gamers actually want, but more importantly, Big Picture mode is ideal for navigating your game library on a massive TV. Another key feature of Steam is that it will let you stream a game from another PC to this one connected to your PC, provided you have the requisite hardware and Nvidia GPU. You can learn more here: <http://dgit.in/1pxaXXJ>
- You can't be a modern geek without your own personal cloud and the simplest way to set it up is by using Tonido. (<http://dgit.in/dgtonido>) It's a free tool that sets up a server on your PC, allowing you to access and stream the contents of your PC to and from a mobile device or other PC.

Simpler alternatives

Setting up a custom-built HTPC rig can be a bit of a pain for some or it may just be too expensive. Regardless, here are some simpler ways to smarten up your TV.

Apple TV

If you're heavily invested in the Apple ecosystem, the Apple TV is the very best option for you. The device gives you access to the entire iTunes library (if you have a U.S. account) and will let you stream content from your iDevices via AirPlay. The main drawback with the device is that it supports a very limited number of file formats.

Amazon Fire TV / Roku

Another great option if you can set up a decent VPN and you don't mind spending about Rs.10,000 a year for access to Amazon's entire library. The devices also give

you access to other services such as Netflix and Hulu.

Chromecast / Miracast / DLNA dongles

These are small devices that you just plug into the HDMI port on your TV, allowing you to stream content from your Android phone and Miracast and/or DLNA compatible devices. This is a decent option to if you want to share something like a family album at a gathering or something.

Android Mini-PCs

These little PCs are about the size of the DLNA dongles, but are as powerful as the average smartphone and are a surprisingly viable and cheap option if you want to stream content from web services or content that any Android device can render even



This tiny device can take you to iHeaven

from a network share. They are usually slow and clunky to navigate, but they're cheap and functional.

Game consoles

Game consoles from the Xbox 360 onwards are very capable multimedia powerhouses that will be more than capable of smartening up your TV. They also usually come with some sort of streaming service in-built, not to mention apps, a TV-ready interface, and a fluid experience that adds to their appeal. To top it off, they're great for gaming as well.

As you can see, smartening up the idiot box is easier than you think. All you need to do is spend as little as ₹5,000 (non-HTPC) and you can transform your TV watching experience. Experiment to find the ideal solution for you; also, don't forget to write in at editor@digit.in with stories of how you smartened up your idiot box. 